

Build, share, and operate agents with control

A sequenced launch plan for Microsoft 365 Copilot and Copilot Studio agents: establish ownership and data boundaries first, then govern delivery, publishing, evidence, and consumption.

Start before build

Personal, read-only productivity agents can use a low-risk lane. Agents shared across a department, connected to business actions, or treated as mission-critical should use an IT-managed Copilot Studio lifecycle.

PHASE 1 | FOUNDATION Establish control

- 1 Classify and assign owners**
Classify personal, departmental, or mission-critical use. Record the business owner, technical owner, backup owner, support contact, audience, risk, cost center, and next review date. [Governance zones >](#)
- 2 Create lifecycle environments**
Use separate development, test, and production environments for shared agents. Attach Microsoft Entra security groups, assign least-privilege roles through group teams, and keep production authoring access small. [Environment strategy >](#)
- 3 Enforce DLP and identity**
Require Microsoft Entra authentication. Allow only approved knowledge types, connectors and tools, HTTP endpoints, skills, and channels. Test that policy violations block publishing before makers proceed. [Configure data policies >](#)

PHASE 2 | DELIVERY Release safely

- 4 Review data and connections**
Review and correct SharePoint permissions before connecting a site as an agent knowledge source. Document each source, endpoint, connection identity, secret, third-party processor, and data-residency exception. Prefer user-context access and least-privilege identities. [SharePoint knowledge access >](#)
- 5 Standardize build and test**
Require scoped instructions, approved tools, safe failure behavior, expected outcomes, abuse cases, a human or support path, and test evidence. Validate with limited users before production review. [Test your agent >](#)
- 6 Promote through controlled ALM**
Package agents and dependencies in custom solutions. Use connection references and environment variables; promote the same version through dev, test, and prod with GCC-supported PAC CLI or Azure DevOps Build Tools. [Solutions and ALM >](#)

PHASE 3 | OPERATIONS Publish and sustain

- 7 Gate sharing and publishing**
Separate Editor from Viewer access and share only with approved groups. Require owner, security/data, test, support, and funding approval. GCC organization-wide Teams and Microsoft 365 publication uses admin submission. [Share agents safely >](#)
- 8 Monitor, retain, and respond**
For standalone agents, set transcript recording, download, retention, and viewer access; enable Dataverse auditing. For Microsoft 365 agents, use GCC-supported Purview controls. Document containment and rollback actions. [Transcript controls >](#)
- 9 Fund, meter, and review**
Choose prepaid, PAYG, or a hybrid based on demand and continuity. Assign a capacity owner and cost center by environment; configure overage routing, alerts, and per-agent limits where available. Review consumption monthly. [Manage credits and capacity >](#)

Minimum production gate

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|------------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------|
| ✓ Primary and backup owners | ✓ Approved audience and risk | ✓ Entra authentication | ✓ DLP policy passes |
| ✓ Versioned solution release | ✓ Security and UAT evidence | ✓ Support and incident path | ✓ Funding and limit decision |

Plan billing, capacity, and guardrails

Choose the funding path and overage behavior before production use.

1. Choose the funding model

Prepaid packs provide a monthly tenant pool. **PAYG** bills consumed credits to Azure. A **hybrid** uses prepaid capacity first and PAYG for overage. [Licensing options >](#)

2. Allocate and route usage

Assign prepaid credits from the tenant pool to environments. At exhaustion, choose whether an environment can draw from remaining tenant capacity, bill a linked PAYG plan, or have no fallback. [Capacity allocation >](#)

3. Decide how usage stops

An environment allocation isn't an exact cap. With no fallback, prepaid usage enters overage and enforcement can disable agents; the monthly count resets rather than reducing the next allocation. PAYG continues billing until stopped. [Overage behavior >](#)